2017 SURVEY OF AUSTIN AREA PRICES OF SELECTED FUNERAL GOODS & SERVICES

Produced and Published by the Funeral Consumers Alliance of Central Texas

Survey procedures

Between January 1 and February 7, 2017, FCACTX volunteers obtained price lists from all 51 funeral establishments physically located in Travis, Williamson, Bastrop, Caldwell, and Hays counties.

The prices in this survey were calculated by reviewing a General Price List (GPL), a Casket Price List (CPL), and an Outer Burial Container (OBC) Price List provided by each funeral home.

Because some funeral homes offer one or more *packages* and others do not offer *packages*, all costs shown in the survey are taken from products and services itemized on the price lists.

Despite the lack of uniformity in the formats and contents of the price lists, every effort was made to assure that this survey compares **exactly the same services for all funeral homes surveyed.**

Survey Chart

The survey chart (pages 3-7) provides the following information:

Column

1 Name, phone number, address
2 Effective dates for 3 price lists (GPL, CPL, OBC)
Cost at each funeral home:
3 Direct cremation
4 Immediate burial with least expensive (minimum) casket
5 Funeral including embalming, visitation, and funeral service (cost of casket not included)
6 Least expensive 20 and 18 gauge metal caskets
7 Embalming option
8 Concrete grave liner for casket
9 Basic services fee (for comparison purposes only)

Definitions, Descriptions, and Notes

1 Name, phone number, address

Funeral homes are listed alphabetically by name rather than by city or zip code. Most funeral providers will travel at least 25 miles (one way) without imposing an extra mileage fee. Extending your options beyond the nearest funeral homes may save you thousands of dollars.

2 Effective dates of General Price Lists (GPLs), Casket Price Lists (CPLs) and Outer Burial Container Price (OBC) Lists

The costs shown are a "snapshot" in time. Funeral homes may change their price lists at any time. It is important to compare the effective date on any price list you pick up during the year with the effective dates of GPLs, CPLs and OBCs used for this price survey.

3 Direct cremation

Direct cremation includes **only**:

- transfer of the deceased from the place of death to a funeral home or mortuary facility
- appropriate care of the remains (usually refrigeration for at least the 48-hour waiting period between death and cremation)
  Some funeral homes include refrigeration in their direct cremation charge – at least for the first 48 hours, but you should **ask if and when refrigeration charges are added to the Direct Cremation cost shown on the GPL.**
- securing all necessary permits and authorizations for the cremation
- an alternative container to encase the body during cremation ("Alternative container" refers to a heavy-duty cardboard or a combination cardboard/wood container.)
- transportation of the body to the crematory
- the cremation itself
- return of the cremated remains **in a secure container** to the family directly or making them available for pickup at the funeral home, and
- all other services of the funeral director and staff (a non-declinable Basic Services fee that is usually reduced for direct cremations).

Crematories are required to return the cremated remains in a **temporary container.** Some funeral homes may attempt to charge for such a container; however, they are not allowed by law to require its purchase (Texas Health & Safety Code, Sec. 716.155).

When decedents weigh over set amounts – e.g., 250, 275 or 300 pounds – there is often an additional charge for the cremation process and for a larger alternate container. There may also be an additional charge for transferring the body to the funeral home and/or crematory.

Some funeral homes charge an additional fee to pick up the deceased at a residence. This is also true with other kinds of funeral arrangements.

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4 Immediate burial

Immediate burial includes **only**:

- transfer of the deceased from the place of death to a funeral home or mortuary
- placement of the body in the funeral home's "minimum" or least expensive casket (usually cloth-covered wood, wood with a veneer, or 20 gauge metal)
- all services of the funeral director and staff (a non-declinable fee that is usually reduced for immediate burials), and
- transportation of the body to a cemetery or other burial site

Immediate burial is usually done within 48 hours of death, sometimes sooner.

Only a few GPLs used in the survey specify refrigeration in their list of immediate burial goods and services. This is important to note because some funeral homes will charge for refrigeration if the deceased is not buried within 24 hours of the time they take possession of the body.

Immediate burial does not include a grave space, opening and closing the grave, a grave liner (if desired by the family or required by the cemetery), or a grave marker.

5 Funeral service

The funeral service in this survey is a hypothetical funeral service. It includes the following goods and services:

- the full non-declinable fee for the basic services of the funeral director and staff, including overhead costs (column 9 in the survey price chart)
- transport of the deceased from the place of death (usually within 25 one-way miles from the funeral home)
- embalming (column 7 in the chart)
- dressing the body and placing it in the casket
- a visitation (at least 4 hours) at the funeral home
- a funeral service at another facility
- use of a hearse or other funeral vehicle for transport of the body to a cemetery
- use of a vehicle to carry flowers to a cemetery
- a "lead car" to transport clergy to the cemetery (This cost can be eliminated by using a private vehicle unless the police escort for the funeral procession requires a lead/clergy car.)

The hypothetical funeral does not include the cost of a casket because selections vary widely and there is no way to know what families will select and from whom they will purchase it. (See **Caskets**, page 8.)

Keep in mind other costs not included in the hypothetical funeral:

- a grave space or plot
- opening and closing the grave
- a grave liner, if desired or required by the cemetery
- a grave marker
- an obituary
- flowers
- services of clergy, organist, vocalist or other musician
- a police escort
- any other services or products not described above

At least some of the costs above must be added to the cost of the items listed for a basic funeral service to get a true picture of the total cost of a funeral service that includes casket burial.

6 Least expensive 20 and 18 gauge metal caskets

The casket prices on the survey chart are for the least expensive 20-gauge metal casket (usually without a gasket), and the least expensive 18-gauge metal casket (usually with a gasket) offered at each funeral home. (See **Caskets**, page 8.)

7 Embalming option

Embalming is not required by law in Texas. You should know that embalming has no public health benefits that have been recognized by any public health authority. At best, it merely slows the natural decomposition process.

Refrigeration, which is a more affordable, non-invasive alternative to embalming, is used for Direct Cremations and Immediate Burials. (See **Slowing Decomposition**, page 8.)

8 Concrete grave liner for casket

If you choose a plot at a cemetery that requires a grave liner or vault, a concrete grave liner is the least expensive option. Prices are included on the funeral home's Outer Burial Container (OBC) price list. Column 8 in the survey chart will allow you to compare funeral home charges for a concrete grave liner with cemetery charges for the same item.

9 Basic services fee

The Basic Services Fee refers to the amount a funeral home chooses to charge for the basic services provided by the funeral director and staff, plus overhead costs.

The Basic Services fees for **Direct Cremation** and **Immediate Burial** are usually calculated by the funeral home at a **reduced** amount.

In the survey chart, Basic Services fees **are included in all prices shown.** The fees are listed in the chart solely to make you aware of the wide variances.

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To understand fully the terms and the prices in the survey chart, refer to pages 1 and 2.
Contact funeral homes to determine any price changes since volunteers collected price lists between January 1 and February 7, 2017.
See pages 8-9 for information on ways to make final arrangements more affordable.

Funeral home name phone street address / city	Effective dates for price lists: GPL CPL OBC	Direct cremation including crematory fee *	Immediate burial with minimum (least expensive) casket **	Basic funeral service not including casket	Lowest cost 20 gauge / 18 gauge metal casket	Embalming option	Concrete grave liner for casket (cost on OBC price list)	Basic Services Fee (only for comparison) Do not add to costs shown in other columns.
Affordable Burial & Cremation Service 512-354-2509 13009 Dessau Rd., Ste. M **Austin**	all 3 lists 10-01-16	$650	$1,350	$3,140 + casket	20 ..... $895 18 ..... $1,645	$700	$625	$525
All Faiths Funeral Services (North location) 512-339-8878 8507 N. IH-35 **Austin**	all 3 lists 10-01-16	$990	$4,370	$4,655 + casket	20 ..... $995 18 ..... $1,995	$625	$795	$1,495
All Faiths Funeral Services (South location) 512-326-8878 4360 S. Congress Ave., Ste. 115 **Austin**	all 3 lists 09-26-16	$795	$2,410	$3,805 + casket	20 ..... $795 18 .....not offered	$625	$795	$895
All Faiths of the Pines 512-237-3836 110 American Legion Rd. **Smithville**	all 3 lists 09-12-16	$1,795 (note 1)	$4,235	$4,955 + casket	20 ..... $1,095 18 ..... $3,195	$695	$895	$1,995
Angel Funeral Home 512-441-9738 1600 S. First St. **Austin**	all 3 lists 08-03-16	$2,445	$4,390	$6,835 + casket	20 ..... $1,195 18 ..... $3,995	$695	$575	$2,995
Austin Cremations 512-777-1699 **(note 2)** 1800 Central Commerce Ct., # 800 **Round Rock**	GPL 03-06-14 CPL N/A OBC N/A	$995	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
Austin-Peel & Son Funeral Home 512-419-7224 607 E. Anderson Ln. **Austin**	all 3 lists 09-01-15	$2,040	$3,290	$4,950 + casket	20 ..... $1,495 18 ..... $2,195	$625	$995	$1,825
Bastrop Providence Funeral Home 512-308-9188 2079 Hwy. 71 E. **Bastrop**	GPL 05-01-15 CPL 10-01-14 OBC 12-01-12	$2,090	$3,593	$5,560 + casket	20 ..... $995 18 ..... $2,595	$895	$695	$2,895
Beck Funeral Chapel & Events 512-778-5300 170 County Road 214 **Liberty Hill**	GPL 09-04-15 CPL 01-15-17 OBC 01-15-17	$1,685	$3,840	$5,105 + casket	20 ..... $1,295 18 ..... $2,395	$995	$995	$1,795

* **Direct Cremation:** **Always** ask the funeral provider if Refrigeration is **included** in the Direct Cremation charge on the General Price List. If it is, ask **how many days** are included before a Refrigeration charge is added. A Refrigeration charge may apply after the period required to secure documents **or** if a delay is requested by family. If the decedent **died** in Travis County, the Travis County Medical Examiner charges **$25** to issue a **Cremation Permit Fee**. This fee is not included in the prices shown.

** **Immediate Burial:** Ask if refrigeration charges are added if burial does not take place within 24 hours.

note 1: The General Price List of All Faiths of the Pines indicates cremation will occur within 10 to 14 business days from the date of the arrangement conference.

note 2: Austin Cremations and Weed-Corley-Fish funeral homes are under common ownership.

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Funeral home name phone street address / city	Effective dates for price lists: GPL CPL OBC	Direct cremation including crematory fee *	Immediate burial with minimum (least expensive) casket **	Basic funeral service <u>not</u> including casket	Lowest cost 20 gauge / 18 gauge metal casket	Embalming option	Concrete grave liner for casket (cost on OBC price list)	Basic Services Fee (only for comparison) <u>Do not add to costs shown in other columns.</u>
Beck Funeral Home 512-244-3772 15709 RR 620 **Austin**	**GPL 07-15-15** **CPL 01-15-17** **OBC 01-15-17**	**$2,685**	**$4,840**	**$6,135** **+ casket**	**20 ..... $1,295** **18 ..... $2,395**	**$995**	**$995**	**$2,695**
Beck Funeral Home 512-259-1610 1700 E. Whitestone **Cedar Park**								
Beck Funeral Home 512-251-3500 4765 Priem Ln. **Pflugerville**								
Condra Funeral Home **(note 3)** 512-352-3636 503 Talbot St. **Taylor**	**all 3 lists** **07-18-16**	**$2,645**	**$4,090**	**$6,690** **+ casket**	**20 ..... $1,095** **18 ..... $2,695**	**$1,095**	**$795**	**$2,730**
Cook-Walden Funeral Home **(note 3)** 512-454-5611 6100 N. Lamar **Austin**	**all 3 lists** **12-19-16**	**$3,040**	**$4,990**	**$8,990** **+ casket**	**20 ..... $1,095** **18 ..... $2,095**	**$1,395**	**$895**	**$4,380**
Cook-Walden/Capital Parks **(note 3)** 512-251-4118 14501 N. IH-35 **Pflugerville**								
Cook-Walden Chapel of the Hills **(note 3)** 512-335-1155 9700 Anderson Mill Rd. **Austin**	**all 3 lists** **12-19-16**	**$3,040**	**$4,990**	**$8,605** **+ casket**	**20 ..... $1,095** **18 ..... $2,095**	**$1,395**	**$895**	**$3,995**
Cook-Walden/Forest Oaks **(note 3)** 512-892-1172 6300 W. William Cannon Dr. **Austin**								
Cook-Walden Davis Funeral Home **(note 3)** 512-863-2564 2900 Williams Dr. **Georgetown**	**all 3 lists** **12-19-16**	**$2,440**	**$3,990**	**$5,560** **+ casket**	**20 ..... $1,095** **18 ..... $2,095**	**$1,395**	**$895**	**$1,595**
DeLeon Funeral Home 512-376-6200 110 E. Cedar St. **Lockhart**	**all 3 lists** **08-01-15**	**$2,065**	**$4,190**	**$5,820** **+ casket**	**20 ..... $1,195** **18 ..... $2,995**	**$595**	**$575**	**$2,795**
Eeds Funeral Home 512-398-2343 408 S. Main St. **Lockhart**	**all 3 lists** **01-01-15**	**$2,300** **(note 4)**	**$3,095** **(within Caldwell County)**	**$4,700** **+ casket**	**20 .....$945** **18 .....$2,195**	**$650**	**$695**	**$1,950**

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** **Immediate Burial:** Ask if refrigeration charges are added if burial does not take place within 24 hours.

note 3: Neptune Society, Condra, Cook-Walden, Fuller-Sheffield, Marrs-Jones, and Marrs-Jones-Newby funeral homes are owned by Service Corporation International (SCI).

note 4: Eeds: GPL says Direct Cremation charge does not include crematory fee. During two phone calls funeral director said the crematory fee is included.

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Funeral home name phone street address / city	Effective dates for price lists: GPL CPL OBC	Direct cremation including crematory fee *	Immediate burial with minimum (least expensive) casket **	Basic funeral service <u>not</u> including casket	Lowest cost 20 gauge / 18 gauge metal casket	Embalming option	Concrete grave liner for casket (cost on OBC price list)	Basic Services Fee (only for comparison) <u>Do not add to costs shown in other columns.</u>
Elgin Funeral Home 512-281-5697 712 N. Avenue C **Elgin**	all 3 lists 04-08-14	$1,675	$2,770	$4,430 + casket	20 ..... $1,095 18 ..... $2,595	$550	$795	$1,400
Fuller-Sheffield Funeral (note 5) 512-476-9164 2808 E. MLK Jr. Blvd. **Austin**	all 3 lists 01-04-17	$2,120	$3,590	$5,120 + casket	20 ..... $1,695 18 ..... $2,795	$995	$595	$2,050
Gabriels Funeral Chapel, The 512-869-8888 393 N. IH-35 **Georgetown**	all 3 lists 08-18-16	$2,225	$2,890	$5,205 + casket	20 ..... $895 18 ..... $1,995	$1,075	$795	$1,895
Gipson-Pendergrass-People's Mortuary 512-237-2365 109 W. First St. **Smithville**	all 3 lists 11-20-15	$1,325	$2,077.75	$3,810 + casket	20 $1,087.50 18 $3,187.50	$675	$500	$1,300
Harrell Funeral Home 512-443-1366 4435 Frontier Trail **Austin**	all 3 lists 05-01-16	$2,895	$4,675	$5,905 + casket	20 ..... $1,395 18 ..... $2,795	$895	$895	$2,495
Harrell Funeral Home 512-382-6543 100 Heritage Dr.& Hwy 290 W. **Dripping Springs**								
Harrell Funeral Home 512-268-8200 1715 Kirby near FM 2770 & Kohlers Crossing **Kyle**								
Heart of Texas Cremation & Burial Service (note 6) 512-243-7277 12010 Hwy. 290 W., Ste. 210 **Austin**	GPL 07-11-16 CPL N/A OBC N/A	$575	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
King-Tears Mortuary 512-476-9128 1300 E. 12th St. **Austin**	GPL 10-24-12 CPL 01-19-07 OBC 01-19-07	$1,940	$3,690	$4,910 + casket	20 ..... $1,195 18 ..... $2,895	$895	$695	$1,950
Legends Tri-County Funeral Service (note 7) 512-256-1220 101-B Centerpoint Rd. **San Marcos**	GPL 06-27-16 CPL 04-27-16 OBC 02-15-16	$625	$2,445	$3,475 + casket	20 ..... $995 18 .....not offered	$525	$625	$750
Life Celebration by Franklin, A 512-365-6000 510 S. Main St. **Taylor**	GPL 11-30-12 CPL 01-09-07 OBC 01-09-07	$1,840	$3,790	$4,510 + casket	20 ..... $1,195 18 ..... $2,895	$795	$695	$1,695

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** **Immediate Burial:** Ask if refrigeration charges are added if burial does not take place within 24 hours.

note 5: Neptune Society, Condra, Cook-Walden, Fuller-Sheffield, Marrs-Jones, and Marrs-Jones-Newby funeral homes are owned by Service Corporation International (SCI).

note 6: Heart of Texas: In the FCACTX service area, this provider's services are available in Caldwell, Hays, Travis, and Williamson Counties.

note 7: Legends Tri-County: In the FCACTX service area, this provider's services are available in Caldwell and Hays Counties.

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Los Angeles Funeral Home 512-392-3676 300 Cheatham St. **San Marcos**	all 3 lists 01-15-17	$2,765	$3,590	$5,475 + casket	20 ..... $1,095 18 ..... $2,595	$795	$695	$1,995
Marrs-Jones Funeral Home (note 8) 512-237-2425 104 Olive St. **Smithville**	all 3 lists 07-18-16	$2,645	$4,090	$6,690 + casket	20 ..... $1,095 18 ..... $2,695	$1,095	$795	$2,730
Marrs-Jones-Newby Funeral Home (note 8) 512-321-2576 505 Old Austin Hwy. **Bastrop**	all 3 lists 12-19-16	$2,645	$4,090	$6,690 + casket	20 ..... $1,095 18 ..... $2,695	$1,095	$795	$2,730
McCurdy Funeral Home 512-398-4791 105 E. Pecan St. **Lockhart**	GPL 04-30-16 CPL 10-15-14 OBC 11-01-13	$3,305	$4,775	$5,560 + casket	20 ..... $1,195 18 ..... $2,795	$575	$750	$2,825
Mission 512-476-4355 1615 E. Cesar Chavez St. **Austin**	all 3 lists 01-15-17	$4,110	$4,890	$5,675 + casket	20 ..... $1,095 18 ..... $2,595	$795	$695	$2,195
Mission Serenity Chapel 512-444-3355 6204 S. First St. **Austin**	all 3 lists 01-15-17	$4,110	$4,890	$6,275 + casket	20 ..... $1,095 18 ..... $2,595	$795	$695	$2,695
Neptune Society (note 8) 512-323-0122 911 W. Anderson Ln., Ste. 111 **Austin**	GPL 03-01-16 CPL N/A OBC N/A	$2,077	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
O'Bannon Funeral Home 830-875-5713 210 S. Laurel St. **Luling**	GPL 10-01-14 CPL 10-01-15 OBC 10-01-14	$2,595	$3,545	$6,545 + casket	20 ..... $1,595 18 ..... $2,995	$995	$995	$2,595
Pennington Funeral Home 512-353-4311 323 N. Comanche St. **San Marcos**	GPL 04-30-16 CPL 10-15-14 OBC 11-01-13	$3,305	$4,775	$5,560 + casket	20 ..... $1,195 18 ..... $2,795	$575	$750	$2,825
Phillips-Upshaw & Richard Funeral Home 512-472-1934 1410 E. 12th St. **Austin**	all 3 lists 01-01-15	$1,310	$2,690	$3,235 + casket	20 ..... $1,195 18 ..... $2,795	$670	$500	$1,250
Providence Funeral Home 512-352-5909 807 Carlos Parker Blvd. N.W. **Taylor**	all 3 lists 10-01-15	$2,190	$3,420	$5,560 + casket	20 ..... $1,295 18 ..... $2,395	$895	$695	$2,895

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Providence-Jones Family Funeral Home 512-281-2340 604 Hwy. 95 N. **Elgin**	**GPL 05-01-15** **CPL 10-16-15** **OBC 05-01-15**	**$1,450**	**$2,575**	**$4,320 + casket**	**20 ..... $975** **18 ..... $2,295**	**$595**	**$795**	**$1,560**
Ramsey Funeral Home 512-869-7775 5600 Williams Dr. **Georgetown**	**all 3 lists 01-06-17**	**$1,999**	**$2,690**	**$4,850 + casket**	**20 ..... $895** **18 ..... $1,995**	**$825**	**$795**	**$1,850**
Solace Eco-Friendly Funeral Services 512-294-1499 1508 W. Koenig Ln. **Austin**	**all 3 lists 02-07-17**	**$1,415**	**$1,494**	**$4,215 + casket**	**20 ..... $999** **18 ..... $1,399**	**$695**	**$899**	**$1,195**
Thomason Funeral Home 512-396-2300 2001 RR 12 **San Marcos**	**GPL 10-01-14** **CPL 10-01-15** **OBC 10-01-14**	**$2,450**	**$3,395**	**$5,450 + casket**	**20 ..... $995** **18 ..... $2,395**	**$450**	**$850**	**$2,750**
Thomason Funeral Home 512-847-2226 14700 RR 12 N. **Wimberley**								
Weed-Corley-Fish Funeral Home 512-452-8811 3125 N. Lamar **Austin**	**GPL 03-01-16** **CPL 03-01-16** **OBC 04-18-15**	**$2,995**	**$4,830**	**$5,765 + casket**	**20 ..... $1,695** **18 ..... $2,495**	**$750**	**$850**	**$2,595**
Weed-Corley-Fish Funeral Home 512-442-1446 2620 S. Congress Ave. **Austin**								
Weed-Corley-Fish (Lake Travis) 512-263-1511 411 RR 620 S. **Lakeway**								
Weed-Corley-Fish Funeral Home 512-260-8800 1200 S. Bagdad Rd. **Leander**								

* **Direct Cremation:** **Always** ask the funeral provider if Refrigeration is **included** in the Direct Cremation charge on the General Price List. If it is, ask **how many days** are included before a Refrigeration charge is added. A Refrigeration charge may apply after the period required to secure documents **or** if a delay is requested by family. If the decedent **died** in Travis County, the Travis County Medical Examiner charges **$25** to issue a **Cremation Permit Fee**. This fee is not included in the prices shown.

* **Immediate Burial:** Ask if refrigeration charges are added if burial does not take place within 24 hours.

All funeral establishments physically located in the counties of Travis, Williamson, Bastrop, Caldwell, and Hays are included in this survey.

Additional Options

- **aCremation:** www.acremation.com. Corporate office/central call center in Mesquite, Texas. Its licensed physical establishment is located in Rockwall, Texas. This business contracts with local mortuary services and crematories to provide all local services. Arrangements are made online and by telephone. On 02-12-17, their website indicated "Remains Pick-Up: 201 Victor St." (Capital Mortuary Services). 1-512-428-8233; 1-877-353-3626
- **Distinctive Life:** www.distinctivelife.com**.** Based in the Houston area. In the Austin area, this business contracts with local mortuary services and crematories to provide refrigeration and cremation services. Phone: 512-407-9780; 512-253-8757
- You may wish to consider a **home or family-led funeral.** See page 8 for more information about this option. See also http://texashomefunerals.com/.

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Cost-saving suggestions for consumers

Comparing prices and knowing your rights. The Federal Trade Commission requires funeral providers to provide price information over the telephone and to supply a copy of their General Price List (GPL) to anyone requesting it in person. Typically, the Casket Price List (CPL) and the Outer Burial Container (OBC) Price List are attached to the GPL. If not, ask for them. The CPL must be shown to you before discussing casket prices.

When offered a package, it is important to examine it closely because not all packages provide discounts. Consider, too, that packages often include goods and/or services you don't want, but you will have to pay for them if you choose the package.

Most funeral homes will modify prices and services to get your business if they know you are willing to go elsewhere for goods and services, and they may not charge you for everything they are allowed by law to charge for.

Reducing final expenses. Choose Immediate Burial, a graveside service, or direct cremation followed by an optional memorial service that can be held almost anywhere people can gather.

Another way to reduce expenses is to compare prices at funeral homes no more than 25 miles from the place where a death has occurred. GPLs indicate how far a funeral provider will travel before charging a mileage fee. Expanding your options beyond a nearby funeral home can sometimes reduce funeral costs significantly. Especially with direct cremation, the location of the funeral home is not a significant factor if you plan to have a memorial service later at another location.

Cost considerations when selecting burial

- If you select Immediate Burial, ask if there will be a charge for refrigeration.
- In determining the total cost for a burial, families need to include the cost of the burial space/plot, the charge to open and close the grave, a grave liner (which is not required by law but **may** be required by a cemetery to simplify grounds maintenance), and a grave marker. Prices vary greatly on these items, depending on the location of the gravesite and the materials used for the grave liner and the marker.
- At smaller, rural, or natural-burial cemeteries, families that wish to do so may often arrange to open and close the grave themselves.

Family-Led Funerals. Families who would like to handle some or all of the arrangements themselves can realize even greater savings with a **home or family-led funeral,** which, in Texas, does not require the services of a funeral director. With the proper authorizations, you may transport the deceased to the cemetery or to a crematory that will deal directly with the public. If you prefer to have a funeral director perform some tasks – such as completing paperwork and obtaining the death certificate – some funeral directors in the Austin area will do this for a fee. See http://texashomefunerals.com.

Slowing decomposition. After 24 hours from the time of death, the law requires that a body must (1) be kept between 34 and 40 degrees; or (2) be kept in an odor-proof and leak-proof container; or (3) be embalmed.

If a body is donated, the donor institution will provide for how the body is maintained or prepared.

Embalming is not required by law in Texas. You should know that embalming has no public health benefits that have been recognized by any public health authority. At best, it merely slows the natural decomposition process.

Even though embalming is not required by law, most funeral directors will not allow a public viewing of a body that has not been embalmed. As shown on the survey price chart, embalming is also a profitable practice.

Refrigeration, which is a more affordable, non-invasive alternative to embalming, is used mostly for Direct Cremations and Immediate Burials.

Refrigeration is used to reduce or control decomposition while awaiting final disposition. Some funeral homes include refrigeration in their direct cremation charge – at least for the first 48 hours – but you should **ask if and when refrigeration charges are added to the costs shown on the GPL for direct cremation and immediate burial.**

Avoid embalming and viewing of the body in the funeral home parlor, a practice falsely promoted by some funeral directors as essential to the grief process. Instead, display pictures and mementos of the deceased at a gathering where sharing and visiting can focus on the memories of the deceased, rather than on an elaborately displayed body in an open casket.

Caskets. Families wanting a 20-ga. or an 18-ga. casket should compare the prices in the survey to the prices for similar caskets available from local casket retailers and online sources (e.g., casket companies, walmart.com, costco.com, amazon.com, and overstock.com).

Metal caskets with rubber gaskets (sealers) will cost more and only affect **how** the body inside decomposes.

Many of these sellers also offer wood and wood veneer caskets as well as cremation urns made of various materials.

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Other casket options include wood caskets available from a variety of sources, including local carpenters and woodworkers.

Families who wish to make the casket themselves can find diagrams in books and on the internet.

"Cremation caskets" are often among the lowest-cost caskets offered at many funeral homes and are suitable for burial as well as cremation. "Alternate containers" – typically used for cremation – are also acceptable for burial.

Consider using a cremation container, a plain wooden casket, or the least expensive casket available. Any casket can be covered with a flag, the deceased's favorite quilt, a religious pall, or other cloth. If desired, you can invite family and friends to write or draw something on the outside of cardboard or unfinished wood caskets, as is sometimes done at home funerals.

Remember, too, that you can buy any kind of casket from sources other than a funeral home. You may also be able to use their prices to negotiate a lower price at the funeral home.

In certain circumstances, such as natural burial, a **shroud** is a choice to consider.

Unreasonable markups. Refrigeration charges are an excellent example of huge markups. According to industry sources, providing refrigeration costs less than $1.00 a day when all acquisition and operation costs are considered. Yet nearly all funeral homes listed in the survey price chart charge more than $50 per day for refrigeration.

Many people who study the economics of the deathcare industry believe that high charges for refrigeration are used to assure that a family will choose embalming, which, in turn, usually results in additional spending for public viewing, a more expensive casket because it will be seen at close range by the public, and often a more expensive outer burial container so the expensive casket is better protected, which should not be a concern since the casket will not be seen again after the interment is over.

Additional extra costs may be incurred at some funeral homes for making arrangements for a service at a location other than the funeral home; for picking up a body beyond certain distances from some funeral homes as noted on those funeral homes' GPLs; for paying with a credit card; and for processing insurance policies. In addition, some funeral homes in the survey identify on their GPLs other extra costs that may be charged.

Other goods and services sold at funeral homes can increase the cost of a funeral significantly – items such as burial clothing, temporary grave markers, bronze caskets costing up to $60,000, bronze vaults costing over $16,000, extra viewing and visitation at the funeral home, alternative casket interiors, a crucifix, a flag case, prayer cards, video presentations, use of chairs/awning/artificial grass at the cemetery for a graveside or committal service, releases of balloons or doves, permanent grave markers or monuments, and other goods and services.

Avoiding manipulation. Don't be led to believe that the more you spend on the funeral or the casket, the greater your love for the deceased. Be wary of appeals to guilt, family pride, and social pressures that can cause you to spend more than you want to spend or can afford.

The funeral industry has depended on the fact that most consumers avoid death and its trappings until they are in the throes of grief just after the death of a loved one. Such feelings can make anyone vulnerable to exploitation and confusion. If faced with this situation, take along a trusted friend for assistance with making arrangements. A friend who is less emotionally involved with the dozens of decisions to be made can give sound advice and help avoid unnecessary expenses.

Discussing your final wishes now. Become an informed consumer now and discuss various disposition options with your family and close friends so they will be prepared to follow your wishes.

Discuss religious questions with a clergyperson or religious leader rather than a funeral director.

Using this survey at a funeral home. Remember to compare the effective date on any price list you are given with the effective dates of the General Price Lists (GPLs), Casket Price Lists (CPLs), and Outer Burial Container (OBC) Price Lists used for this price survey.

Burial Benefits for veterans and their spouses. Complete information about burial benefits for veterans and their spouses, scheduling, and more at www.cem.va.gov, or call 1-800-827-1000.

Burial on private property in an incorporated city, town, or village is subject to that entity's zoning regulations or other related ordinances. Burial outside a municipality is generally unregulated. Burial on private property creates an encumbrance on the land if it is ever sold. Information on establishing a family cemetery can be found online at www.txca.us/resources/documents/establishing%20a%20family%20cemetery.pdf

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